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the Migrant's Voice

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BRAC celebrated International Migrants Day on 18 December 2014

Migration programme, BRAC celebrated International Migrants Day on 18 December 2014 as the international day of solidarity with migrants to recognise the rights of Bangladeshi migrants working throughout the world. This date was chosen because it was on 18 December 1990 when the General Assembly of United Nations adopted the International Convention on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of Their Families. Later on 4 December in 2000, the UN General Assembly, declared 18 December as International Migrants Day recognizing contribution of the migrants in the world.

BRAC in association with the Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment, celebrated the day countrywide with enthusiasm. *Nirapod obhibashon, din bodoler lokho orjon* was the theme of this year.

Honourable Minister, Eng Khandkar Mosharraf Hossain, Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment, was the chair of the inagural programme held at Bangabandhu International Conference Centre (BICC). He also expressed solidarity at signature campaign of BRAC. A cultural event took place followed by the inauguration of the migration fair. BRAC and National Alliances for Migrant Rights (NAMR,B) participated in the rally and fair to celebrate the event.

BRAC demonstrated and distributed materials on safe migration, remittance management and reintegration among the migrants, visitors and guests. BRAC in association with OKUP and WARBE DF also organised a seminar on Reintegration of the returnee migrant workers: opportunities and challenges at the same venue.

The day to honour the unsung heroes

> "Let us make migration work for the benefit of migrants and countries alike. We owe this to the millions of migrants who, through their courage, vitality and dreams, help make out societies more prosperous, resilient and diverse."

Ban Ki-moon,Message for International Migrants Day, 18 December 2013

International Migrants Day is an international day observed on December 18 as International Migrants Day appointed by the General Assembly of United Nations on December 4, 2000 taking into account the large and increasing number of migrants in the world. On December 18, 1990, the General Assembly adopted the international convention on the protection of the rights of migrant workers and members of their families.

This day is observed in many countries, intergovernmental and non-governmental organisations through the dissemination of information on human rights and fundamental political freedoms of migrants, and through sharing of experiences and the design of actions to ensure the protection of migrants. Bangladeshi government, civil society organisation, migrants rights based national-international organisations, migration service providers observes this day each year to mark this day as a commitment for protecting rights and promoting safe migration in Bangladesh.

BRAC also undertakes series of activity, like nationwide rally, demonstrate stall in Migration fair in collaboration with the Ministry of Expatriates' and Overseas Employment every year. This year BRAC will directly provide support to government to celebrate the day at 42 districts of the country.

International Volunteer Day (IVD)

http://en.wikipedia.org

International Volunteer Day (IVD) is a chance for volunteer-involving organisations and individual volunteers to promote their contributions to development at local, national and international levels. By merging UN support with a grassroots mandate, IVD is a unique opportunity for volunteer-involving organisations to work with government agencies, non-profit organisations, community groups and the private sector. IVD was established by the United Nations (UN) General Assembly through Resolution 40/212 on 17 December 1985. Since then, governments, the UN system and civil society organisations have successfully joined volunteers around the world to celebrate the Day on 5 December.

Volunteers are the nucleus force now a day for BRAC migration programme. Currently, there are ,1417 trained volunteers working with the programme at grassroots to promote safe migration and support returnee migrants for their reintegration. Migration progamme volunteers are youth, who are dedicated to promote and protect the rights of the migrant workers; and many of the volunteers are returnee migrants who work in the community as peer educators.

We salute these volunteers in the International volunteers' day for their tremendous contribution and working together for the migrant workers of Bangladesh.

The neglected crisis: seaborne exodus from Bangladesh

No one knows how many migrants have died in the last ten years attempting to cross in small boats from Bangladesh to any south east asian countries. According to the findings of RMMRU at least 20,000 migrant workers were trafficked in 2013 and the number is even higher this year. According to United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, 87,000 people have been migrating to Malaysia or Thailand illegally since 2012. Various statistics indicated that an upward trend continued in the first half of 2014.. This illegal migration has become a highly lucrative business which seems firmly to be in the hands of organised criminals.

Get there or die: After fighting with unemployment, insecurity and hopelessness many rural Bangladeshi youth view abroad as a promised land that they are prepared to risk their lives to reach there. In doing so, many of the Bangladeshi migrant workers became victims of organised slave trade. They were lured by those slave traders and then shipped to Thailand and were held in jungle camps or houses until relatives secure their release by paying the traffickers a ransom. These ill fated people were sometimes tortured by traffickers at jungle camps in southern Thailand until their families secured their release with ransoms of USD 2,000 or more.

Unprecedented number of trafficking through sea: These migrants' flow is not homogenous but 'mixed flows' of economic migrants and refugees. There is some reason to believe that in 2013–2014 people-smuggling became better organised through Bay of Bengal. According to migration experts, shrinking of legal channels of labour migration to Malaysia is one of the major causes of the rising number of illegal migrant workers through sea.

Action against smugglers: The issue's humanitarian core is simple: if people set sail in vessels that are not seaworthy, a proportion of them will die. Patrol boats are not the answer but action against smugglers is needed.

Sharing information, meeting needs: One vital task is to gather information about the boat crisis and produce a reasonably accurate death toll, disseminate and publicize that. Credible public information campaigns about the risks of illegal boat migration could then be undertaken. While tougher action against the people smugglers would appear to be one realistic short-term option to reduce the number of unnecessary deaths at sea.

Major humanitarian crisis

On 23 November Bangladesh Navy rescued over 600 overseas job seekers from Bay of Bengal who are believed to be lured by human traffickers of Malaysia. Among this 600, 20 are women and children.

On 13 October, Thai police found a number of sick and exhausted people in a boat hiding on a remote island, all but one of the 79 suspected human trafficking victims were from Bangladesh.

On 12 June 5 Bangladeshis were killed and at least 151 were injured when a gang of miscreants from Myanmar opened fire on trawlet, carrying over 300 people illegally to Malaysia, in the Bay of Bengal.

On 2 February, 50 people from Ukhia upazilla of Cox's Bazar were rescued when the fortune seekers were being traffcked to Malaysia.

Shared responsibilities in protecting the rights of Bangladeshi migrants

About nine million Bangladeshi had migrated abroad for work and contributed US $ 14 billion as remittance to the national economy of Bangladesh in 2013. The greatest contributors of national GDP's rights are not protected in home and destinations. To address the issue of the migrant workers a platform named National Alliances for Migrants Rights Bangladesh (NAMR,B) was formed .

In June, 2014 NAMR,B organised a national level consultation on, "Kafala violating migrant rights: Can FIFA help to abolish?" The consultation targeted to advocate for the protection of the migrant workers through FIFA as Qatar was then selected as the host for FIFA world cup 2022. Speakers at the consultation targeted to advocate for the protection of the migrant workers in Gulf Cooperation Countries (GCC) through FIFA and other international organisations so that they can force the GCC countries to abolish the maleficent Kafala system existing in those countries. A position paper has also developed in relation to that.

In August, 2014 NAMR,B raised its voice for demanding justice for the victims of Greece shooting incident which was taken place in 2013 and where 33 of Bangladeshi migrant workers, working as strawberry picker, got injured. In 2014 Greece court gave a veridict which went in favour of the accused shooter. The alliance organised a press conference at the National Press Club titled, "Greece verdict should be reviewed" so that the Bangladeshi migrant workers get justice.

NAMR,B is formed by various organisations working for protecting the rights of the migrant workers, such as BRAC, BASTOB, Bangladeshi Obhibashi Mohila Sramik Association (BOMSA), Dhaka Ahsania Mission, INAFI Bangladesh, OKKAF, Ain o Shalish Kendra (ASK), Shikha Shastha Unnayan Karzakram (SHISUK) Manusher Jonno Foundation (MJF) and CARE Bangladesh are the of NAMR,B.

BRAC Migration programme addressing the remittance management issue

Remittance is the second biggest foreign currency earning sector after exports; give a much needed cushion to the government to face a rising pressure on the country's balance of payments (BoP).

Despite significant contribution of remittance to Bangladeshi economy, in many cases, migrant workers and their families are unable to utilise their earned money properly due to lack of knowledge about remittance management. Considering this fact, BRAC's Migration programme is implementing awareness and skill development programme for the potential and returnee migrants and their families. This programme aims to improve their knowledge and skill on proper remittance management. For this purpose a Remittance management flip chart also has been developed.

The redeemer of the community

The contribution of the volunteers to BRAC Migration is incomparable. Volunteers play a very crucial role in the BRAC's migration programme. Currently there are1,417 trained migration programme volunteers, among which 309 are female and 1,108 are male. These volunteers are trained in safe migration issues through a comprehensive training programme.

The migration programme volunteers are involved in carrying out different activities, like assisting potential migrants in migration process, filling up passport form and at the registration of District Employment Manpower Office (DEMO), conducting courtyard meetings, IPT shows, conducting interpersonal communications (IPC) and also facilitating socioeconomic reintegration of returnee migrant workers after they return home.

According to Seikh Suraiya from Dhaka Region, "I was motivated to volunteer for the BRAC's migration programme by observing the number of helpless migrants and also because my relatives suggested that this would be a great thing to do. The migrants did not know where to go for help. So, I came forward to support them through my work. It feels great to work for the people with BRAC. I have seen positive changes in the community. Now people do not go to the middle-man. They seek help from the volunteers."

Like many other volunteers, Suraiya's noble thoughts and the kindness with which she executes her work to empower the community are really inspiring. This young girl has successfully inspired many people in their locality to migrate safely following the proper legal process. Many of the volunteers are neither a migrant nor a migrant's family member, yet they came forward to reduce the plight of the migrants.

The volunteers are the back bone of the BRAC's migration programme. Without them the BRAC's migration programme would not have been as successful as it is today in ensuring safe migration. BRAC proudly acknowledges and salutes the spirit with which these volunteers are moving forward to bring a positive change in the community.

First reintegration training module for the Bangladeshi migrant workers

Reintegration assistance is critical to facilitating sustainable returns and development in both host and countries of origin. If reintegration of these migrant workers is not addressed properly then a number of returnee migrant workers will not stay in the country of origin or will be compelled to live in an unsuitable living condition at home.

To assist the reintegration of the returnee migrant workers BRAC has developed a module which has nine chapters.

This module is the first reintegration module in Bangladesh. It is expected that this initiative will help the returnee migrant workers reintegration process.

Interactive popular theatre show at cultural event for Malaysian Human Resource Minister

In 18 August 2014 Ministry of Expatriate's welfare and overseas employment arranged a cultural event in the honour of Malaysian Human Resource Minister, His Excellency Sri Richard Riot Anak Jaem. BRAC's migration programme presented an interactive popular theatre show in the cultural evening with the support of the Community Empowerment Programme (CEP); the show focused on the importance of safe migration, G2G process of labour sending to Malaysia from Bangladesh, important steps of safe migration process and information reletaed to safe migration.

The event was attended by the honourable Minister Engineer Mr Khandker Mosharraf Hossain, M.P., Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment; Honorable State Minister Mr Md.Shahriar Alam, M.P; Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Government of Bangladesh, the principle Secretary to the Prime Minister of Bangladesh Mr Abdus Sobhan Sikder; the Director General of Bureau of Manpower , Employment and Training (BMET), Ms Shamsun Nahar; the secretary of Civil aviation and tourism, Mr Khorshed Alam; the foreign Secretary of the Government of Bangladesh, Mr. Md. Shahidul Haque; the Director of BRAC's gender, justice and diversity, and migration programme, Ms Sheepa Hafiza; the Programme Head of BRAC's migration programme, Mr Hassan Imam and other valued guests.

The third Peace Building Fund Advisory Group presents its Final Report to the Secretary-General of the United Nations

The third Peace Building Fund Advisory Group holds its last meeting on 7 and 8 October 2014. This group was nominated in 2012, it has accompanied the Peace Building Fund for three years, meeting twice a year and focusing on four strategic priorities for the Fund: (i) strengthening the Fund's strategic positioning; (ii) improving the monitoring and evaluation of the Fund; (iii) increasing its cooperation with international financial institutions; and (4) strengthening the gender dimension in PBF's work.

The Peace Building Fund has proven to be a unique instrument with a strong track record of providing flexible and timely support to address key peacebuilding issues in settings where other funding was not readily available. The Advisory Group has seen a number of improvements over the past three years, including in the Fund's monitoring and evaluation, partnerships with other organisations and gender-responsiveness. In going forward, the Fund will need to continue to push for greater country level UN ownership, leadership and coherence as well as for broader inclusivity of the national partners. The Fund will also need to continue to seek innovative ways of strengthening gender responsiveness of its interventions.

Sheepa Hafiza, director GJ&D and Migration programme BRAC was one of the member of this nine-member group.

Source: http://www.undpbf.org

The route back home

In Bangladesh, migration is chosen as a livelihood strategy by many people especially by the low skilled workers. The majority of the people from Bangladesh migrate as low skilled workers most of their destination are the middle eastern countries and Malaysia. Due to the job nature of these migrant workers most of them come back to the country after three to four years. But the long absences from their loved ones, lack of a familiar community and various unwanted situation in the country of destination make them vulnerable. These vulnerabilities of the migrant workers need to be addressed through socioeconomic support their upon return.

The returnee migrant workers primarily need two type of reintegration support economic and social. BRAC's previous interventions are mainly focused in the pre departure stage. However BRAC's field level experience found out that it is essential to address the need of the migrant workers in the return stage as well. For that, with the support of UN WOMEN, BRAC has initiated a project for socioeconomic reintegration of the returnee migrant workers. The project has planned to educate returnee migrant workers specially the women migrants, vulnerable male migrant and their family members on how they can use their earned remittance in a productive way and how they can reintegrate with their family and society at selected areas. The project will be initiated in three migration prone districts where the numbers of women migrant workers are high. The districts are Dhaka, Manikganj and Faridpur. The secondary participants consist of line institutions dealing with migration services (both government and private), local government, media, human rights and law enforcing organisations.

The proposed project is expecting changes at local, sub-national and national level. Firstly, the skill of the returnee migrant workers from the selected upazillas will be increased and thus employment and self employment opportunities will be also enhanced allowing migrants to have better and healthier life with their family and community after their return, livelihood of migrants' families will also improve significantly. Secondly, returnee migrant works who were deceived, exploited and abused will have necessary social support that will help them to rehabilitate and reintegrate in the society. Finally, migrants will have enabling environment that will help them to recognise their contribution and uphold their rights and dignity. This initiative of BRAC will reduce the vulnerabilities of the returnee migrant workers and will make their journey back home safe and secure.

Seminar on reintegration of the returnee migrant workers: opportunities and challenges

At a seminar on 'Reintegration of the returnee migrant workers: opportunities and challenges' organised by BRAC in association with OKUP and WARBE DF at Bangabandhu International Conference Centre (BICC) on 18 December 2014, speakers demanded a new reintegration policy and database for returnee Bangladeshi migrants.

In his presentation Mr. Hassan Imam, programme Head, Migration programme, BRAC recommended separate reintegration policy and strategy and pointed out the importance of reintegration. He also made suggestionson creating a returnee database for the returnee migrants.

Speaking as the chief guest of the seminar, Honourable Minister, Engineer Khandker Mosharraf Hossain, MP, Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment acknowledged that reintegration is the most important part of migration management and government will consider this issue. He appreciated the organisers and stated that, this is first time he is hearing about reintegration issue during his 6 years tenure as a minister of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment.

Mr. Khandakar Md. Iftekhar Haider, Secretary, Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment, highlighted the needs for initiatives for protecting the rights of the returnee migrants.

Focusing on the need for reintegration policy and a new database for returnee migrants, Ms. Sheepa Hafiza, Director, Gender Justice and Diversity and Migration programme, BRAC urged for collective initiatives for social and economic reintegration.

Among others, Ms. Saheen Anam, Manusher Jonno Foundation, Mr. Shakirul Islam (Chairman, Ovibashi Karmi Unnayan Program –OKUP and Mr. Faruque Ahmed, WARBE DF, participated in the discussion. The programme was presided over by Begum Shamsun Nahar, Director General, Bureau of Manpower Employment and Training (BMET).

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